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Symbols, Struggle, and Stagnation: The Role of the PFLP in the Palestinian National Movement

A Term Paper

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I. General Introduction

The Israeli-Palestinian conflict is among the longest-standing and most complex geopolitical conflicts of the modern period, propelled by cross-cutting nationalisms, land, and historic grievance. The conflict was further heightened following the 1948 Arab-Israeli War, which led to the displacement of hundreds of thousands of Palestinians, a past recalled by the Palestinians as the Nakba, or "catastrophe" (Khalidi, 2020). Over the subsequent decades, the conflict evolved through war, peace negotiations, and intermittent violence, and it shaped the politics of the Middle East. Over this course, various Palestinian groups were established with their own distinct ideologies and strategies for realizing Palestinian self-rule and statehood.

The Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP) was founded in 1967 by Palestinian Christian physician and former member of the Arab Nationalist Movement (ANM) George Habash (Sayigh, 1997). The PFLP quickly became a prominent Marxist-Leninist party advocated the liberation of Palestine through armed struggle and revolutionary socialism shortly after its inception. Unlike other Palestinian factions that engaged in diplomatic diplomacy, the PFLP emphasized militant struggle and sought to locate the Palestinian struggle within global anti-imperialist and socialist movements. This ideological foundation positioned the PFLP as a radical political alternative within the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO) and in the broader Palestinian national movement.

Historically, the PFLP was formed as a response to Arab countries' loss during the 1967 Six-Day War and Israel's occupation of Palestinian territory. The organization criticized the state of Israel's legitimacy and opposed any peace treaty that did not ensure the full liberation of Palestine. The PFLP vision was for a single democratic state where Arabs and Jews coexisted with equal rights, diametrically opposite to the two-state solution embraced by other Palestinian movements (Hroub, 2006). The hardline stance led to the PFLP's controversial reputation in Palestinian society and internationally.

The PFLP rose to international fame with its creative use of "propaganda of the deed" tactics, including a series of high-profile airplane hijackings and bombings during the late 1960s and early 1970s. They were designed to universalize the Palestinian struggle and challenge Western and Israeli hegemony (Sayigh, 1997). While these activities increased the exposure of the PFLP, they also led to being labeled a terror organization by countries such as the United States, the European Union, Canada, and Japan (US Department of State, 2023). This has created a problem for the PFLP in terms of engaging diplomatically and impacted how individuals around the world view the Palestinian liberation movement.

Though its violent methods have been denounced, the PFLP has played a significant role in Palestinian political and resistance rhetoric. The PFLP has consistently spurned peace treaties such as the Oslo Accords as Palestinian

compromises of sovereignty and rights (Hroub, 2006). The PFLP continues to advocate armed struggle and revolutionary change instead, and staying afloat despite shifting regional politics and internal Palestinian fissiparous politics. Its military wing, the Abu Ali Mustafa Brigades, on the other hand, remains active within Gaza and the West Bank, pointing towards the ongoing challenge of achieving peace and stability.

The PFLP is an important, albeit problematic, chapter in Palestinian nationalist history. Its Marxist-Leninist theory, commitment to armed struggle, and internationalist outlook distinguish it from other Palestinian groups. To make sense of the PFLP's origins, ideology, and role within the broader Israeli-Palestinian conflict, one has to understand the politics of Palestinian resistance and the sophistication of Middle Eastern self-determination.

II. Related Literature and Other Studies

A. The Genesis of Radicalism

In December 1967, George Habash formed the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP) in response to the profound and traumatic changes affecting the Arab world following the Six-Day War. As a Palestinian Christian and physician, Habash was deeply influenced by the trauma of the Nakba in 1948 and his political development in the Arab Nationalist Movement. The establishment of the PFLP marked a firm shift towards Marxist-Leninist ideology in Palestinian resistance. Its initial manifestos

proclaimed a vision of prolonged people's war, merging class struggle with anti-colonial liberation. The leadership of the organization contended that Arab regime failure and the disintegration of pan-Arab unity made it mandatory to have a revolutionary vanguard committed to armed struggle, not merely against Israel but also against Western imperialism and reactionary Arab regimes (Miller, 2023). The PFLP's intransigent position soon distinguished it from Fatah, the ruling group in the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), that was more receptive to pragmatic nationalism and negotiations. The PFLP drew its popular base from urban intellectuals, university students, and refugees, especially in Jordan and Lebanon, where it also began social and educational institutions to establish grassroots legitimacy (European Council on Foreign Relations [ECFR], 2023). The group's extremism and autonomy of operations, however, soon began to create tension with Middle Eastern powers, most dramatically during the run-up to Black September in Jordan in 1970.

B. International Operations and "Propaganda of the Deed"

The PFLP became infamous for its "propaganda of the deed," high visibility acts of violence meant to garner international attention to the Palestinian cause. Wadie Haddad's External Operations department coordinated a campaign of hijackings, bombings, and attacks aimed at Western countries around the globe. In 1968, the PFLP hijacked an El Al flight to Algeria establishing a precedent for hostage taking as a bargaining tool to further

release Palestinian detainees and obtain international media attention (Miller, 2023). The hijacking of 1970 at Dawson's Field with four aircraft hijacked and flown to a remote airstrip in Jordan eventually developed into a standoff that caused the Jordanian monarchy to crack down on Palestinian organizations. The 1972 Lod Airport massacre, which it carried out with the Japanese Red Army, showed that the PFLP was capable of forming international alliances for its operations. These raids accomplished their goal of internationalizing the Palestinian issue, but drew international condemnation as well as designation of the PFLP as a terrorist organisation by the United States, the European Union and other states (U.S. Department of the Treasury, 2024). By the late 1970s, the success of these strategies ebbed as the group was facing increasing pressure from regional actors and international counterterrorism initiatives, particularly after the passing away of Haddad, who was extensively held responsible by Israeli intelligence (Miller, 2023).

C. Relationships with International Revolutionary Movements

Since its founding, the PFLP has regarded the Palestinian resistance as an integrated part of the wider international struggle against imperialism and capitalism. In the Cold War period, the organization benefited from the sponsorship of the Soviet Union and China, both of which perceived Palestinian resistance as constituting a component of their ideological rivalry with the West (ECFR, 2023).

The PFLP also forged close working relationships with a variety of left-wing militant organizations, such as the Japanese Red Army, Germany's Red Army Faction, and figures like "Carlos the Jackal." These ties were not just tactical in nature but were indicative of an intense ideological commitment to internationalism and revolutionary solidarity. PFLP camps in Lebanon became a center for international violence, and its membership attended international meetings of anti-imperialist groups. The deterioration of the global left and the ascendancy of political Islam during the 1980s and 1990s also chipped away at these networks, delegitimizing the ideological claims of the PFLP (Miller 2023; ECFR 2023).

D. The Oslo Accords and PFLP's Rejection

The Oslo Accords in the 1990s had a watershed effect on Palestinian politics and drove the PFLP more to the periphery. The organization was an outspoken and bitter critic of Oslo, with its members believing that the accords represented a surrender to Israeli and Western pressures and a sell-out of top Palestinian rights, such as the right of return for the refugees. The PFLP refused to participate in the PA governments created by Oslo and supported continued armed struggle and appeal for one (secular) democratic state in historic Palestine (ECFR, 2023). The boycott was ideological, based on the group's Marxist-Leninist commitment to unyielding struggle, and strategic, out of concern that Oslo security cooperation could criminalize resistance, and divide the Palestinian movement. This process therefore helped to isolate the PFLP within the

PLO as movements like Hamas was to grow in popularity by claiming to be the authentic voice of resistance (Miller 2023).

D. Current Activities and Challenges

Today, the PFLP is still the second-largest of the PLO factions but its power has largely been lost. The fall of the Soviet Union deprived the party of a key source of funding, and the emergence of Islamist parties altered the political equilibrium in Palestinian politics. The PFLP's militant wing, the Abu Ali Mustafa Brigades, still exists in Gaza and sections of the West Bank and tends to act in collaboration with Hamas and Palestinian Islamic Jihad. The organization has claimed authorship of a variety of attacks in the 21st century, such as the assassination of Israeli Tourism Minister Rehavam Ze'evi in 2001 and the 2014 Jerusalem synagogue attack. Of late, the PFLP has been involved in combined operations during large-scale escalations, including the October 7, 2023, attacks in southern Israel, which attracted global criticism and resumed examination from Western governments (NGO Monitor, 2024; U.S. Department of the Treasury, 2024).

The PFLP encounters a multitude of difficulties in the modern day. Its Marxist, secular ideology lost most of its appeal in an area now shaped by political Islam as the language of resistance. Fostart, the organization is financially stretched, having lost Soviet sponsorship and PLO funding, the latter of which was suspended in 2016. International sanctions and anti-terrorist regulations further limited it from raising funds, and the group

increasingly turned to Iranian sponsorship and diaspora contributions. In 2024, the US and Canada placed new sanctions on PFLP financiers for sending millions of dollars via cryptocurrency and other hidden channels (U.S. Department of the Treasury, 2024). There have also been restrictions on organizational leadership capability within the group; Ahmad Sa'adat, who has been the General Secretary of the PFLP since 2001, has been in Israeli prisons since 2006, and limited capability for communication has led to internal rifts and divergences of strategy (ECFR, 2023).

The PFLP's legitimacy has also been challenged by charges that it has militarized Palestinian civil society. In 2022, the Israeli government declared several Palestinian NGOs to be fronts for the PFLP, a step which was strongly contested by global human rights groups but which nonetheless placed the group under greater scrutiny for its social and political activities (NGO Monitor, 2024). The PFLP has a presence within the Palestinian National Council and youth and women's committees within refugee camps but is increasingly eclipsed by more extensive Islamist social infrastructure.

Overall, the PFLP's historical importance derives from its pioneering of transnational armed struggle and continued critique of political compromise with Israel. Although its power has diminished with the decline of the old regional order and generational change, the organization remains a badge of unyielding opposition for a portion of the disillusioned Palestinian population

with the Palestinian Authority and Hamas. The future of the PFLP will hinge on whether it can ideologically evolve, access sustainable means, and navigate the intricacies of Palestinian politics in the new century. Its own legacy is securely set, though, as a case study in the potentialities and limitations of revolutionary violence in contemporary Middle East.

III. Course Implication

The development and history of the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP) provide a rich framework through which to study the interaction of conflict, security, and development—central AB International Development themes. The organization arose in a background of statelessness, chronic conflict, and regional insecurity, in which classic development was overpowered by a struggle centered on liberation. The PFLP's resistance to diplomatic settlement initiatives such as the Oslo Accords and its consistent armed struggle demonstrate a conviction that true development and self-governance can never be achieved under occupation and foreign control (Hroub, 2006; Miller, 2023). This demonstrates the conflict between peacebuilding actions and local conceptions of justice and sovereignty.

The PFLP's activism also demonstrates the difficulties in state-building and governance amidst strong non-state actors. Although it was not officially a part of the Palestinian Authority government structure, the PFLP held considerable power through its militant, social, and education wings. It operated

as a de facto government in various refugee camps, especially in Lebanon and Gaza, where it enjoyed street credibility (European Council on Foreign Relations, 2023). This complicates typical development narratives, which tend to presume the existence of a legitimate and centralized state actor as a pre-condition for progress.

Ideology and identity are centrally located in the PFLP's revolutionary platform, making it a rich case study of resistance in development contexts. Marxist-Leninist ideology is the theoretical foundation of the PFLP, and it combined class struggle and national liberation as aims, aiming to counter both zoning occupation and global capitalism (Sayigh, 1997). Its coordination with international left movements such as the Japanese Red Army and Red Army Faction reflects how transnational ideological solidarity informed its behavior and legitimacy (Miller, 2023). These ideological imperatives inform not only the means of resistance, but also the visions of development and governance for such groups.

The PFLP's decline highlights how changing global ideology and regional politics impact non-state actors and their capacity. The fall of the Soviet Union eliminated one of the principal sources of ideological and financial backing, while the emergence of Islamist movements and donor conditionalities re-shaped the Palestine political development space (ECFR, 2023). In addition, contemporary counterterrorism policies, including financial sanctions and organizational

proscriptions, have suppressed the PFLP's activities and diplomatically isolated it (U.S. Department of the Treasury, 2024). This reflects how global security regimes can shape the development trajectories of both state and non-state actors.

For students of AB International Development, the PFLP provides valuable lessons on the intricacy of resistance politics, the strength of ideology, and the resilience of non-state actors in influencing development outcomes. The case illustrates the shortcomings of top-down paradigms and the need for situating local histories, identities, and political realities at the center of development frameworks. In areas of continued conflict and occupation, there is a need to understand groups such as the PFLP to develop informed, context-specific, and sustainable development policies.

V. Commentary

The Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP) is still one of the more complex and contentious groups in the wider Palestinian resistance movement. Its unyielding position and militant tactics have very often placed it in conflict with global norms and changing expectations on the part of the Palestinian people. Personally, examining the PFLP's legacy is challenging—while their rhetoric on liberation and equality resonates with anti-colonial narratives, their methods and ideological rigidity often overshadow their goals. It raises

difficult questions: Can armed resistance still be justified in the 21st century? And if so, to what extent?

From a critical standpoint, the PFLP's impact has been both symbolic and divisive. Their dismissal of the two-state solution and their dream of one democratic state may seem utopian, but it has no practical avenues. Their demands for armed struggle, although based on their Marxist-Leninist ideology, have not come with practical advances toward Palestinian statehood. At worst, it has isolated them further from both the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO) and the international diplomatic community (Hroub, 2006).

Although the PFLP did manage to internationalize the Palestinian issue in the 1970s using its sensational hijackings and bombings, these same actions ultimately had a rebound effect. They elicited severe criticism from the world powers and served to cement the perception of Palestinian resistance as being one with terrorism. In doing so, the PFLP helped to delegitimize the movement they sought to bring into prominence (Sayigh, 1997). This paradox is perhaps one of their biggest failures—to opt for fame over long-term political momentum.

In re-evaluating its effectiveness, it is evident that the PFLP has not succeeded much in its adaptation. Other groups, such as Fatah and Hamas, for all their own shortcomings, have at least participated in political procedures or been responsive to shifting geopolitical realities. The PFLP, on the other hand,

seems stuck in a moment in time—still using models that were maybe more salient in the Cold War era. Their armed wing, Abu Ali Mustafa Brigades, continues to exist, though their impact is overshadowed by more powerful players in the region (International Crisis Group, 2022).

One should also weigh the moral consequences of their plan. Revolutionary violence may be historically justifiable, particularly in situations of occupation and repression, but in the interconnected, legally formalized world of the present day, such tactics risk being a step too far and into war crimes. The Geneva Conventions, for instance, ban attacks on non-combatants—a principle that the PFLP's methods have not always adhered to. Accordingly, the organization's actions are routinely denounced under international law (United Nations General Assembly, 2004).

In addition, the PFLP's ideological basis—though originally inspiring to some of the leftist movements—has become progressively out of touch. The world left has developed to adopt nonviolence, diversity, and transnational justice movements. The PFLP's adherence to militarism and its antiquated Marxist jargon renders it disconnected from today's social justice struggles, even among those sympathetic in the West (Gunning, 2008).

The international community's attitude towards the PFLP is strongly defined by this history. Countries like the United States, Canada, and members of the

European Union have labeled it a terrorist group (US Department of State, 2023). This designation not only restricts the PFLP in finding allies but also impacts the wider Palestinian cause by placing a cloud over legitimate calls for self-determination. Alas, the group's recent history has also provided a handy rationale for some states to eschew more serious engagement with the Palestinian question entirely.

All the same, one should not reduce the PFLP to caricature. They are a strand of Palestinian resistance that demands dignity and will not accept a "lesser" peace—a peace that provides economic relief without substantive sovereignty. Their criticisms of international failures of the Oslo Accords are legitimate (Hroub, 2006). Nevertheless, idealism without a clear and fair plan has a way of degenerating into violence or irrelevance, and the PFLP appears trapped between the two.

In looking back at their legacy, it is possible to see that the PFLP is both a prisoner and a product of its time. Their unshakeable vision for justice can be admired, but their inability to deal positively with changing political circumstances has made them irrelevant. Peace, if and when it arrives, will probably need a new type of resistance—a resistance built upon diplomacy, inclusivity, and law, and not merely ideology and weaponry.

Finally, the PFLP remains a symbol of resistance at its most extreme. It is a tale of passion, anger, and rejection—but one of lost opportunities and moral uncertainty as well. Today, their ongoing militancy serves the Palestinian struggle not at all. If anything, it might harm it. The story of the PFLP, then, is not one of what they struggled against, but also of what they would not modify—and in that reluctance is the tragedy of their potential and their collapse.

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